



Virtualisation Out-of-the-Box

Fedora 10 neither offers the geeky Xen, nor the easy-to-use VirtualBox, and yet it's a virtualisation powerhouse. Huh? Did I miss something?

2006 was a grand year for virtualisation fans. And why not? SUSE Linux Enterprise introduced the much-hyped Xen in its official offering. Meanwhile, kernel 2.6.20 integrated KVM (Kernel Virtual Machine) in its main tree, which Fedora 7 packed in the following year.

While Xen offers a pretty complicated offering—requiring you to boot a patched Xen kernel to create and run virtual machines—KVM is a loadable module that works with the distribution's default kernel. The only requirement is that your processor should have the hardware assists for virtualisation, which most processors that came out in the last few years, do have.

LFY did carry a tutorial on KVM in its October 2007 virtualisation special issue. It talked about how to get started with this technology using the default command-line

tools. Although that may be the preferred way for most geeks, us plebs would rather have everything as GUI wizards that don't require us to remember too much command-line jargon.

Fedora 10: It's only KVM!

Going back to as early as Fedora 7, the project introduced one tool called the Virt-Manager, which integrated support for Xen, KVM and Qemu. With the latest Fedora 10, there's however no Xen kernel being offered. Take a look at Figure 1—it's only KVM under the virtualisation section. Seems like the die-hard Xen fans would have to wait another six months for Fedora 11. Like I care!

For my virtualisation needs, I've been using the VirtualBox OSE edition that many distros pack in by default, viz. Mandriva, openSUSE, etc, for a while now. So, after installing Fedora 10, I obviously had plans to install it. But alas!